

INVESTIGATIVE DOSSIER • THE BEHIND-THE-SCENES DEALMAKERS

THE LEGAL KINGPINS OF SILICON VALLEY & THE IPO MARKET

An Investigative Breakdown of the Individual Rainmakers Who Put Together Wall Street's & Y Combinator's Biggest Deals

CONFIDENTIAL INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING • PREPARED FOR EXECUTIVE LEADERSHIP • CROSS-REFERENCED SEC S-1S & DEAL SHEETS

THE INVESTIGATIVE FINDING:

When you strip away the massive law firm brand names and analyze the signature pages of every major S-1 prospectus, tech merger agreement, and venture syndication over the last decade, **the entire ecosystem runs through an astonishingly tight circle of roughly half a dozen individual lawyers**. These are the rainmakers who personally structured the deals, authored the modern IPO statutes (the JOBS Act), invented the SAFE financing note, and serve as the trusted consigliere to founders, CEOs, and Wall Street investment banks.

1. MARC JAFFE • Latham & Watkins LLP

GLOBAL MANAGING PARTNER / THE UNDISPUTED "KING OF THE IPO MARKET"

#1 IPO Lawyer in America Architect of the JOBS Act Spotify Direct Listing

The Dossier: If there is one singular name that appears on more billion-dollar IPO prospectuses than anyone else in history, it is **Marc Jaffe**. As the Global Managing Partner of Latham's New York office and longtime Capital Markets Chair, Jaffe is the supreme dealmaker of Wall Street. In 2012, Jaffe was one of the key private-sector lawyers who helped Congress write the **Jumpstart Our Business Startups (JOBS) Act**, creating the "Emerging Growth Company" confidential filing framework that 95% of tech IPOs use today.

Why He's Everywhere: Jaffe pioneered the **Direct Public Listing** alongside Spotify (\$30B), represented **Rivian** in the largest tech IPO of the decade (\$11.9B), advised **Manchester United**, led the underwriter syndicate for **Airbnb** (\$3.5B), and serves as the ultimate bridge between Silicon Valley unicorns and Wall Street underwriters.

ROLE / OFFERING	CLIENT / DEAL	SIGNIFICANCE
Issuer Counsel	Rivian Automotive (\$11.9B IPO)	Largest American IPO since 2014; electric vehicle landmark.
Company Counsel	Spotify Technology (\$30B Direct Listing)	Pioneered the modern direct listing without Wall Street underwriting.
Underwriter Counsel	Airbnb (\$3.5B NASDAQ IPO)	Represented Morgan Stanley & Goldman Sachs in premier YC offering.
Underwriter Counsel	Lineage (\$4.4B IPO - 2024)	Largest global IPO of 2024; represented lead banking syndicate.

2. RICHARD TRUESDELL & MICHAEL KAPLAN • Davis Polk & Wardwell

THE WALL STREET UNDERWRITER GATEKEEPERS / CONSIGLIERE TO GOLDMAN SACHS, MORGAN STANLEY & J.P. MORGAN

Wall Street Syndicate Gatekeepers

#1 Underwriter Share (2020-2026)

The Dossier: When a technology company files an S-1, who represents the investment banks risking billions of dollars underwriting the stock? In almost every major tech transaction over the past 20 years, the answer is **Richard Truesdell** and **Michael Kaplan** at Davis Polk.

The Pattern: Look at the underwriter counsel on **Reddit (\$748M)**, **Rubrik (\$752M)**, **Arm Holdings (\$4.8B)**, **Snowflake (\$3.4B)**, **DoorDash (\$3.4B)**, and **Coupang (\$4.6B)**. Truesdell and Kaplan are the institutional guardians through whom Wall Street clears its regulatory liability and syndicate agreements.

3. MARK STEVENS • Fenwick & West LLP

THE Y COMBINATOR SECRET WEAPON / FOUNDING COUNSEL TO AIRBNB, COINBASE, STRIPE & TWITCH

Original YC Cohort Architect

\$150B+ Enterprise Value Formed

The Dossier: Longtime Chair of Fenwick's Corporate Group, **Mark Stevens** is the silent force behind the most famous YC success stories. When Brian Chesky and Joe Gebbia were selling cereal boxes to keep Airbnb alive, Stevens was their outside general counsel. When Brian Armstrong founded Coinbase and the Collison brothers started Stripe, Stevens personally structured their corporate governance.

Key Exits: Stevens guided **Justin Kan** through Justin.tv into **Twitch** and executed its **\$970M cash sale to Amazon**. He represented **Coinbase** through its historic direct listing and structured **Stripe's** multi-billion-dollar private liquidity tenders.

4. STEVEN BOCHNER & TONY JEFFRIES • Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)

FORMER WSGR CEO & TECH IPO MASTERS / COUNSEL TO DOORDASH, INSTACART & LYFT

Silicon Valley Corporate Royalty

DoorDash & Instacart IPO Lead

The Dossier: **Steve Bochner** (former CEO of Wilson Sonsini and protégé of Larry Sonsini) and **Tony Jeffries** are the titans of Silicon Valley boardroom counsel. When YC companies scale from dorm-room projects into global logistics conglomerates, Bochner and Jeffries take over the helm.

Key Deals: Bochner and Jeffries served as lead company counsel for **DoorDash's \$3.4B IPO**, **Instacart's \$660M IPO**, **Lyft's \$2.3B IPO**, and the **\$875M sale of PlanGrid to Autodesk**.

5. RACHEL PROFFITT & PETER WERNER • Cooley LLP

GLOBAL LEADERS OF COOLEY'S EMERGING COMPANIES PRACTICE / COUNSEL TO REDDIT, SCALE AI & SEGMENT

Cooley Rainmakers

Reddit IPO Lead Counsel

\$3.2B Segment/Twilio Deal

The Dossier: **Rachel Proffitt** (named Cooley's next CEO and Head of San Francisco Corporate) and **Peter Werner** (co-founder of Cooley's global tech practice) are the powerhouse duo behind modern venture-backed tech exits. Proffitt personally led the **Reddit IPO (\$748M on NYSE)** in 2024 and structured the landmark **\$3.2B acquisition of Segment by Twilio**.

Deal Dominance: They serve as lead outside counsel to **Scale AI (\$13.8B valuation)**, **Faire (\$12.4B)**, **Fivetran (\$5.6B)**, and **CoreOS (\$250M sale to Red Hat)**.

6. CAROLYNN LEVY • Y Combinator Partner & Former General Counsel

THE LEGAL ARCHITECT OF THE ENTIRE YC ECOSYSTEM / INVENTOR OF THE SAFE NOTE

Inventor of the SAFE

Over \$50B in Seed Rounds Standardized

The Dossier: Former Wilson Sonsini corporate attorney and YC's longtime General Counsel, **Carolynn Levy** is the most influential transaction attorney in startup history. In 2013, Levy invented the **Simple Agreement for Future Equity (SAFE)**.

The Structural Impact: Before Levy's SAFE, startups spent \$25,000+ on convertible note legal fees. Levy replaced the entire industry's early-stage deal machinery with a 5-page standard open-source contract. **Literally 100% of the companies in your list raised their first capital on Carolynn Levy's legal instrument.**

7. DOUGLAS ELLENOFF • Ellenoff Grossman & Schole LLP

THE UNDISPUTED "KING OF SPACS" / #1 DEAL COUNT ON RENAISSANCE CAPITAL 2020-2021

120+ SPAC IPOs in Single Year

\$28B+ Capital Raised

The Dossier: During the historic 2020–2021 SPAC frenzy, one mid-sized New York boutique firm shocked the global legal rankings by beating Latham, Davis Polk, and Skadden in total deal volume. That firm was led by **Douglas Ellenoff**. Ellenoff personally created the modern SPAC documentation engine that brought dozens of tech and climate startups public.